

Trump imperils forests, critics contend

He advocated ‘raking,’ but his contract freeze makes that type of work hard, firefighters and lawmakers say.

By JAMES RAINEY

President Trump has insisted that “raking” of the forests and other fuel reduction measures would help prevent wildfires from devastating the West. But early actions by his administration have frozen one of the key programs to complete that sort of work, weeks after a pair of giant fires devastated broad stretches of Altadena and Pacific Palisades.

The administration’s block on some Bureau of Land Management contracts comes at the same time that it has frozen most federal government hiring—an action that has led to confusion at the U.S. Forest Service, where the hiring of some firefighters has been postponed.

A White House spokesperson said the Department of the Interior, which oversees the Bureau of Land Management, is reviewing funding decisions to ensure they are consistent with Trump’s executive orders. That review is focusing, in part, on spending approved under President Biden’s Bipartisan Infrastructure Law and Inflation Reduction Act.

A pair of firefighter unions and dozens of Democrats in Congress have condemned the Trump administration’s hold on the contracts and the hiring delay, saying the actions defy common sense and Trump’s admonitions about the way to reduce the threat of wildfires.

California’s two U.S. senators, Alex Padilla and Adam Schiff, joined a dozen other Western senators in demanding that the Bureau of Land Management lift its hold on the wildland “treatment” contracts that pay

[See Fire, A12]



Photographs by GENARO MOLINA Los Angeles Times

MIKE AND DNA Moore lost their Malibu home in the 2018 Woolsey fire. They are still waiting to move into a new house.

YEARS AFTER DISASTER, A STRUGGLE TO REBUILD

Mike and DNA Moore moved to Malibu in the late 1990s when DNA was pregnant with their first child. They raised three kids in the community, and their youngest now coaches volleyball at Malibu High School, his alma mater. Over the years, DNA has worked with dozens of local families as a physical therapist treating children with developmental disabilities. Their lives are so entwined in Malibu that when the Woolsey fire burned down their two-story, Cape Cod-style house in late 2018, the Moores had no doubt they were going to rebuild.

“Home is where the heart is,” said DNA Moore, 53. “My broken heart is here.”

More than six years after the fire, the Moores are still waiting to move into a new house. Caught in a tangle of government permitting rules, the couple have yet to secure approval to break ground.

“Every time we submit our plans, it comes back with another half a dozen line items to address,” said Mike Moore, also

Malibu homeowners displaced in 2018 are tangled in bureaucracy and worry latest fires will add to delay

By Liam Dillon



FEWER THAN 40% of the 465 homes destroyed in 2018 have been reconstructed. Above, a house near the Moore property.

53. “When is this going to end?”

Fewer than 40% of the 465 Malibu homes destroyed in the Woolsey fire have been reconstructed, according to city statistics. Many reasons contribute. Homeowners might be unwilling because of fire-related trauma to start anew in the same place they used to live. Some might be underinsured. One-fifth of affected homeowners have not submitted any rebuilding plans to the city.

But for the Moores and many others, the problem has been navigating the web of regulations controlling what can get built along California’s coastline.

The Moores’ struggles represent a nightmare scenario for property owners hoping to come back quickly after last month’s Eaton and Palisades fires devoured more than 11,600 homes in Altadena, Pacific Palisades, Malibu and surrounding communities. Gov. Gavin Newsom, Los Angeles Mayor Karen Bass and L.A. County officials have promised to fast-track ap

[See Malibu, A12]

COLUMN ONE

This town faced its hardest decisions after the wildfire

A fire raged several hillsides away from their house on the afternoon of Feb. 7, 2009, David Barton reassured his wife: “Don’t worry. Entire towns don’t burn down.”

By that evening, as he watched a 150-foot-high wall of flames closing in, it was clear he had been very wrong.

“Everything so very quickly turned so very ugly,” he recalled.

Weeks of record heat had baked the region to a crisp, and the fire, sparked by a downed power line, had spread in the 80-mph winds before sharply veering into town.

Barton climbed into his old Toyota and began evacuating stunned residents.

[See Australia, A4]

Experts warned the Aussies not to rebuild. They wouldn’t listen.

By MAX KIM AND MARIA PETRAKIS
REPORTING FROM MARYSVILLE, AUSTRALIA



David Barton

DAVID BARTON lost his home in Marysville, Australia, in a 2009 wildfire that killed 173 people.

A quandary for diplomat Rubio

The secretary of State has dueling objectives on his Mideast trip: peace and Trump’s Gaza vision. **WORLD, A3**

Leonard Cohen’s estate files suit

Singer-songwriter’s heirs accuse his former attorney of fraud in bid to pilfer \$50-million fortune. **BUSINESS, A8**

L.A.’s Asians fear ICE raids

Rumors swirl among immigrant communities of plans to conduct mass deportations. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

Weather

Mostly sunny. L.A. Basin: 69/50. **B6**

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How Education nominee could affect California

Trump has tasked Linda McMahon with dismantling the federal department.

By HOWARD BLUME, JAWEED KALEEM, TERESA WATANABE AND JENNY GOLD

Linda McMahon, President Trump’s nominee to head the U.S. Department of Education, stood in solidarity last week with his goal of dismantling the department — an overhaul that could affect how billions of dollars in K-12 funding, financial aid and student loans flow to California schools and colleges.

McMahon told lawmakers

during her Senate confirmation hearing that federal funding for students in need would continue — including Title I funding for schools that serve low-income families and funds for students with disabilities. The Education Department also assists low-income college students, students who are learning English and protects students’ civil rights.

One day after the hearing, the Department of Education Office for Civil Rights released a letter to K-12 and higher education administrators indicating it would tie federal funding to the elimination of diversity, equity and inclusion programs.

The letter said schools using “race in decisions pertaining to admissions, hiring

[See McMahon, A6]



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